decades. And bear in mind that this is not happening in isolation. Other powers, especially those of a middle plus capability and a regional dominance, also have similar aspirations. The multiplicity of power centres is an increasingly visible characteristic of our times. India matters because it is central to the emergence of multipolarity, whether in Asia or in the world.

We are also once again in times when the importance of norms and behaviour has assumed greater significance. There are few nations who would not assert their commitment to international law or respect for agreements and regimes to which they are party. But actual observance can be quite another matter. The example that has captured attention in recent times pertains to the UNCLOS 1982 and its application in the South China Sea. India took a principled approach to this matter by underlining that it supported freedom of navigation and overflight as well as unimpeded commerce, based on principles of international law as reflected in the UNCLOS. It also urged all parties to show utmost respect for the UNCLOS, which establishes the international legal order of the seas and oceans. More importantly, India led by the power of example when it accepted an arbitration verdict on its own maritime boundary dispute with Bangladesh.

Another debate that has also featured in contemporary consciousness relates to the relevance of connectivity to world politics. Here, too, India has been among the earliest to enunciate an objective and fair position. In essence, it declared that connectivity initiatives must be based on recognized international norms, good governance, rule of law, openness, transparency and equality. They must be financially responsible, avoid creating an unsustainable debt burden, balance ecological and environmental protection, transparently assess costs and have a local ownership. Connectivity projects must be pursued in a manner that respects sovereignty and territorial integrity.

While respect for international law is essential to any global order, it is also evident that following its letter but not spirit has had damaging consequences. When systems are gamed and the underlying principles skirted through semantics, clearly the world emerges the worse for it. It is no accident that in the light of recent experiences, there is a global interest in a rules-based order. This is not to be treated as a derogation of law but as going beyond it to promote norms. India matters as an advocate of a rules-based order.